

Academic pressure and non-medical use of study drugs

1. Newspaper article and source

Our selected newspaper article is Rachel Goldsmith's "Campus researchers address student usage of 'study drugs' and potential consequences", published on 19 April 2026 in Pipe Dream. Pipe Dream is Binghamton University's independent student newspaper, founded in 1946, with a print edition and an editorial newsroom; this is a reported news article rather than a personal blog. Its campus focus makes it directly relevant to students and university support services.

Source: <https://www.bupipedream.com/news/campus-researchers-address-student-usage-of-study-drugs-and-potential-consequences/179120/>

Publisher background: <https://www.bupipedream.com/about/>

The original article is in English, so no translation is required. The appendix preserves the original screenshot supplied with our report, including the headline, author, date and article text.

2. The societal challenge in our own words

Our challenge is non-medical use of prescription medicines for studying under academic pressure. Students may take these medicines without a prescription or use them differently from their prescribed treatment because they expect greater concentration or productivity. This raises questions about student wellbeing, expectations of performance and access to support. Medically indicated treatment must be distinguished from misuse: receiving an ADHD prescription does not establish inappropriate use.

The news article describes campus experiences and interviews with researchers and counselling staff. Its informal survey cannot establish how common misuse is among all students. We therefore use scientific research to assess the wider evidence rather than treating a campus news story as a representative prevalence study.

3. Why we are interested

As students, we experience academic pressure and recognise the temptation to seek shortcuts when deadlines accumulate. We are concerned both about peers' wellbeing and about the belief that taking medication is necessary to keep up. We want to understand the evidence behind these beliefs and explore how structured information could support better questions about prescription patterns. Our own experiences motivate the project; they are not evidence of how widespread misuse is.

4. Stakeholders

- Students: need reliable information, appropriate treatment and accessible support without stigma.
- University staff and counselling services: can use evidence to develop wellbeing support and address academic pressure.
- Doctors and other healthcare providers: need to distinguish appropriate treatment from non-medical use and support patients responsibly.
- Parents and families: may support students experiencing stress or medication-related difficulties.
- People receiving prescribed ADHD treatment: could be harmed if legitimate treatment is confused with misuse.
- Employers: have an interest in how expectations of constant productivity extend beyond university.

5. Four complementary scientific articles

Paper 1: Prevalence and quality of evidence

Jones and Newton (2024) review surveys of cognitive-enhancer use among UK university students. Subtype: peer-reviewed brief report synthesising survey evidence. Their analysis shows why sampling matters: the included studies did not use representative sampling, and evidence of an increase over time was inconclusive. This helps us avoid generalising campus anecdotes to all students. It also shows that self-reported use and prescription records answer different questions. Its UK focus limits direct transfer to other countries.

Paper 2: Benefits, harms and uncertainty

Schifano et al. (2022) examine cognitive enhancers in healthy individuals. Subtype: peer-reviewed review article. They discuss uncertain benefits and possible cardiovascular, neurological and psychological complications. The review helps explain why perceived improvements should not be treated as proof of safe or effective academic enhancement. It also supports distinguishing non-medical use in healthy individuals from clinically indicated treatment. Because it covers several substances and heterogeneous evidence, it does not establish that every drug has identical effects or that every user experiences harm.

Paper 3: Access through informal markets

Demant et al. (2020) study prescription-drug distribution through observations of Swedish Facebook drug markets. Subtype: peer-reviewed original qualitative research. This adds a social perspective: access to medicines can extend beyond formal prescribing. It helps explain why a prescription database alone cannot measure all non-medical use. Its findings concern a particular online market and should not be treated as a prevalence estimate for university students or as a description of every social-media platform.

Paper 4: Testing claims of cognitive enhancement

Ilieva et al. (2015) analyse 48 studies involving 1,409 participants to assess stimulant effects on selected cognitive functions in healthy people. Subtype: peer-reviewed meta-analysis. They find benefits on some tasks but conclude that overall enhancement is probably modest, with publication-bias concerns affecting some findings. This complements the broader review by directly assessing the magnitude of cognitive effects. Laboratory task improvements do not automatically establish better grades, long-term benefits or safety. The paper helps us frame academic-enhancement claims cautiously.

6. Synthesis and implications for our database

Together, these papers address prevalence, potential harms, informal access and cognitive effects. They support a focused project on prescription patterns while showing its limits. Our database records students, doctors, medicines and prescriptions, allowing questions about prescription history, frequency and differences between programmes. It does not currently record diagnoses, actual consumption, non-prescribed purchases, motivation, academic pressure or outcomes. Consequently, it cannot identify misuse, evaluate clinical appropriateness or establish that medication causes academic success or harm. Those questions would require additional suitable data and careful study design.

References (APA style)

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Appendix: original newspaper screenshot (1)



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NEWS

Campus researchers address student usage of 'study drugs' and potential consequences



Adderall, a stimulant often prescribed to treat attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder, is commonly abused by students to increase productivity and academic performance.

Researchers at Binghamton University have found that stressed students who use Adderall tend to believe it is a safer alternative to caffeine, cannabis and cocaine, but consequences can create serious short-term and long-term challenges.

By RACHEL GOLDSMITH - APRIL 19, 2024

The use of "study drugs" to promote focus while tackling papers and exams has become ubiquitous on college campuses. Adderall, a central nervous stimulant prescribed to treat attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder or narcolepsy, is commonly abused by students to increase productivity and academic performance.

In response to Pipe Dream's informal drug survey, 28 out of 78, or approximately 36 percent of responders, said they have used Adderall, Ritalin or another stimulant before studying.

"I took Adderall at 10 p.m. the night before my chem final and could not sleep the entire night before it," said one anonymous responder.

Binghamton Student Managed Adderall Research Team is a student-run research group focused on the abuse of study drugs and was founded in 2018 by Lina Begdache Ph.D. '08, an associate professor of health and wellness studies. Research from the group found that students who use Adderall as a study drug do so to promote concentration and determined that BU students often think Adderall is safer than caffeine, marijuana and cocaine because it is a prescription drug, Begdache told Pipe Dream.

According to a 2024 study led by Begdache, using study drugs can lead to addiction to cannabis, alcohol and other substances.

"Substance use promotes the release of the neurotransmitter dopamine, which is responsible for the initial euphoria and feelings of pleasure," Begdache told BingUNews. "These sensations act as a positive reinforcement for further substance use. The continuous activation of the limbic system through drug use leads to dependence, in a sense that this substance is no longer producing pleasurable feelings. Individuals have to either increase the dose or resort to something more potent."

B-SMART researcher Zachary Costanza, a sophomore majoring in integrative neuroscience, explained that college students are particularly susceptible to using study drugs.

"Ultimately, college is really the perfect storm for many of the risk factors that are associated with Adderall use," Costanza wrote in a statement to Pipe Dream. "Students, especially here at Binghamton, face intense academic pressures, sleep deprivation, and an environment that often glorifies productivity at all costs. These factors, combined with the misconceptions that Adderall will improve academic outcomes, are exactly why stimulants get framed socially as an effective shortcut."

Costanza described the various negative effects of adderall abuse for young people. Adderall increases dopamine levels in the brain, which "mimic[s] the effects of many other recreational drugs" and can eventually lead to a decrease in natural dopamine production. This can cause people to feel less

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Appendix: original newspaper screenshot (2)

dopamine levels in the brain, which "mimic[s] the effects of many other recreational drugs" and can eventually lead to a decrease in natural dopamine production. This can cause people to feel less motivation or focus overall, according to Costanza.

Chris Downey, the director of the University Counseling Center, explained some of the reasons University students might use stimulants.

"These may include academic pressure, attempts to improve efficiency, difficulty balancing energy and social/academic demands, self-managing underlying mental health concerns, concentration problems, euphoria or thrill-seeking, and cultural normalization," Downey wrote in an email to Pipe Dream. "Study drugs can seem appealing as the impacts can be fast-acting and powerful, but their consequences can create short-term or long-term challenges and are rarely sustainable."

The UCC provides resources for students struggling with study drugs, including a space to discuss the issue, identify healthier alternatives and perform a consultation for ADHD or significant attention problems. For students seeking treatment, the UCC offers individual counseling with an addiction specialist, group therapy and referrals to off-campus addiction service providers.

Begdache emphasized the dangers of reliance on Adderall as a study drug, arguing that it disrupts sleep, affects long-term memory and can permanently change brain function in young people. She recommends those abusing Adderall to "seek help right away" to prevent irreversible damage.

She also explained that because of the drug's impact on long-term memory, its use might not result in improved academic performance.

"People take Adderall to improve their grades and we found that those who use it on a regular basis tend to have lower GPAs," Begdache said.

While abusing study drugs can lead to dependency and other detriments to students, stimulants are often an effective treatment for certain conditions. However, even prescribed Adderall might have negative effects, Begdache added, and as a dietitian, she recommends physicians consider lifestyle factors before prescribing.

J. David Jentsch, a distinguished professor and chair of psychology and researcher of addictive substances, said that Adderall will have negative effects on anyone taking it, but in some instances, like for patients with ADHD, its positive impacts will outweigh the negative consequences. Dosage adjustments by medical professionals can also limit negative effects, he added.

"Any kind of prescription medication, there's a reason they're prescribed, because we need advice and consent in order to use them," said Jentsch.

Editor's Note (4/22): A previous version of this article listed Lina Begdache as an assistant professor of health and wellness studies. Begdache is an associate professor.

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